

Risk Is Unavoidable. Panic Is Optional.

LAST CHAPTER, WE discussed how and why we respond to threats: Our limbic system's immediate surge of adrenaline urges us to take action. This has been built into us slightly cleverer primates over millions of years, an evolutionary development that has helped make our species one of the most successful on the planet.³⁰⁹

At least, when it comes to adaptation and survival. Our species has been much less clever in terms of allocating capital in markets than we have been in dominating the planet.

Douglas Adams' charmingly witty absurdity *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy* begins with this reveal: Arthur Dent discovers his friend Ford Prefect is not human—he is a Betelgeusian.³¹⁰ Oh, and the Earth is about to be destroyed by the Vogons, who are building a hyperspatial express route straight through our solar system.

Ford lends Arthur his copy of *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy*, which is the galaxy's bestselling book:

It is said that despite its many glaring (and occasionally fatal) inaccuracies, the *Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy* itself has outsold the *Encyclopedia Galactica* because it is slightly cheaper, and because it has the words 'DON'T PANIC' in large, friendly letters on the cover.

"Don't Panic" turns out to be excellent advice when your wetware urges you to have an immediate reaction to perceived threats (real or otherwise). Unfortunately, most of the time, this advice is useless. No one responds well to being told to "calm down!" when they are in their fight or flight mode.

To ensure you understand why "Don't Panic" is such good advice—now,